



KT2

Course Enquiry: Why has peace proved so elusive in the Middle East?

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L1: KT2.1: The Six Day War, 1967

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Understand the significance of the Cairo Conference (1964) and the growth of Fatah and the PLO.
- ☐ Analyze the escalating tension between Israel, Syria and Jordan: Syria's support for Fatah, Israel's raid on Samu and the events of 7 April 1967.
- ☐ Evaluate the actions of the USSR, Nasser and the USA in the period leading to war, and the key events of the war.

In June 1967, tensions reached a boiling point. Arab armies massed on Israel's borders, and fiery rhetoric promised Israel's destruction. But in a stunning, pre-emptive strike, Israel destroyed the entire Egyptian air force on the ground. In just six days, the geopolitical landscape of the region was completely transformed.

Did you know?

- **Pre-emptive Strike:** Israel launched Operation Focus, destroying over 300 Egyptian aircraft in a few hours.
- **Golan Heights:** Israel captured this strategic high ground from Syria, heavily fortifying its northern border.
- **Sinai Peninsula:** Israel conquered the vast Sinai desert, creating a huge buffer zone between themselves and Egypt.

Do Now Activity

1. Who became the President of Egypt in 1954 and positioned himself as the leading champion of Pan-Arabism?
2. What was the name of the highly secret agreement signed in October 1956 where Britain, France, and Israel planned the tripartite invasion of Egypt?
3. Explain the immediate cause behind Nasser's decision to nationalise the Suez Canal Company on 26 July 1956.
4. What was the 1955 Gaza Raid, and why was it a turning point for Egyptian defense policy?
5. How did Nasser successfully bypass Western weapons restrictions in September 1955 to rearm Egypt?

Vocabulary Check

Fill in the blanks using the vocabulary words below.

PLO (Palestine Liberation Organisation) | Fatah | Pre-emptive Strike | Casus Belli

In the 1960s, Palestinian nationalism grew stronger with the creation of the _____, an umbrella organization, and its dominant guerrilla faction, _____. Border tensions flared violently when Israel launched the _____ into the West Bank in 1966. These escalating events eventually culminated in

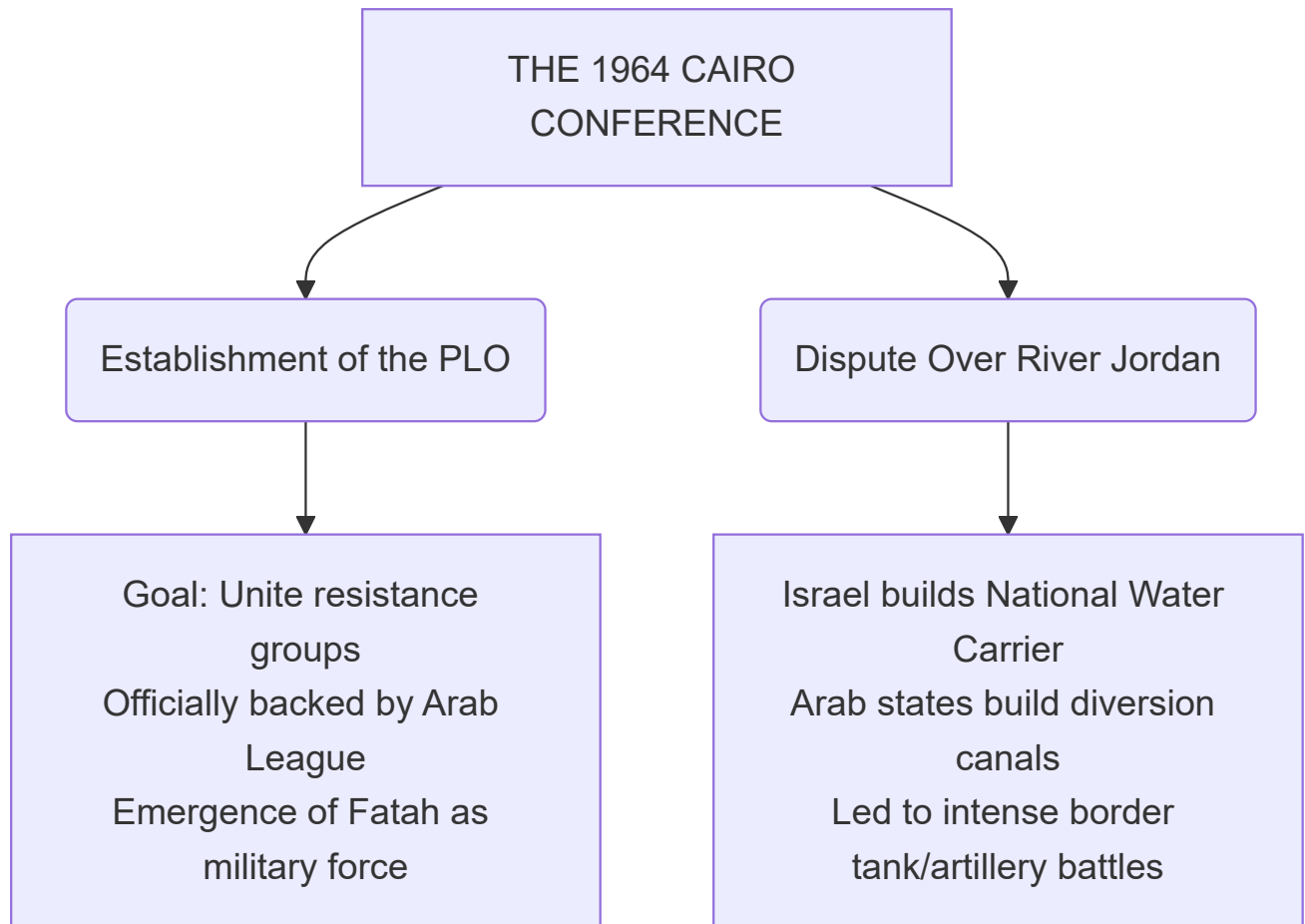
June 1967 when Israel launched _____, a devastating pre-emptive air strike that wiped out the Arab air forces on the ground.

SPECIFICATION STUDY MAP: KEY TOPIC 2.1

1. **Palestinian Nationalism** → Cairo Conference (1964), creation of the PLO and Fatah.
2. **Border Wars & Skirmishes** → Disputes over Jordan water, Samu Raid (1966), 7 April 1967.
3. **The Slide to War (May '67)** → Soviet misinformation, UNEF withdrawal, closure of Tiran.
4. **The Six Day War** → June 5 pre-emptive strike, lightning land war, redrawn boundaries.

The decade of relative border peace secured by the UN Emergency Force (UNEF) buffer began to disintegrate in the mid-1960s as a new wave of radical Palestinian nationalism swept the region. In January 1964, President Nasser hosted the historic Cairo Conference of the Arab League. At this summit, Arab leaders took the monumental step of establishing the Palestine Liberation Organisation (PLO). The primary objective of the PLO was to unite various Palestinian resistance groups under a single political umbrella to destroy the State of Israel and reclaim the lost homeland for the Palestinian refugees.

Q1. What was the primary objective of the Palestine Liberation Organisation (PLO) when it was established at the 1964 Cairo Conference?



Alongside this diplomatic development, a radical guerrilla movement called Fatah (founded in 1959 by **Yasser Arafat**) began to dominate Palestinian military activity. Unlike older Arab politicians who relied on conventional state-to-state warfare, Fatah believed that only a grassroots, irregular guerrilla war could liberate Palestine. At the Cairo Conference, tensions also flared over a vital shared resource: water. Israel had completed its massive National Water Carrier engineering project to divert fresh water from the Sea of Galilee south to irrigate the Negev Desert. Viewing this as an act of aggression, Arab leaders at the conference agreed to divert the headwaters of the River Jordan (specifically the Dan and Banias rivers) inside Syria and Lebanon to starve Israel of water.

Q2. How did the dispute over the River Jordan escalate tensions between Israel and the Arab states in the mid-1960s?

By 1965, this dispute erupted into an active border war. Whenever Syrian workers began building diversion canals, Israeli tanks and artillery fired across the border to destroy their heavy machinery, driving Syria and Israel into a cycle of violent border clashes. By 1966, the border between Israel and its Arab neighbours had become a volatile combat zone. This escalation was fueled primarily by a radical, left-wing military coup in Syria in February 1966.

The new Syrian government adopted a fiercely aggressive posture toward Israel. They began actively sponsoring Fatah, providing Palestinian guerrilla fighters with funds, modern explosives, and training bases inside Syrian territory. From these bases, Fatah launched a relentless campaign of cross-border sabotage raids into Israel. Rather than attacking the Syrian military directly, Israel's retaliatory strikes focused on the countries from which Fatah fighters infiltrated, pushing relations to the breaking point:

Q3. How did the new Syrian government support the Fatah guerrilla movement from 1966 onwards?

Syria funds/arms Fatah
guerrillas

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graph TD; A[Syria funds/arms Fatah guerrillas] --> B[Fatah launches sabotage raids into Israel]; B --> C[IDF launches massive reprisal on Jordanian Samu]; C --> D[ ];
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Fatah launches sabotage
raids into Israel

IDF launches massive
reprisal on Jordanian Samu

King Hussein is deeply alienated

The Samu Raid (November 1966): After a Fatah landmine killed three Israeli border policemen, Prime Minister Levi Eshkol ordered a massive reprisal raid into Jordan, which controlled the West Bank. On 13 November 1966, 600 IDF troops backed by tanks swept into the Jordanian village of Samu, dynamiting dozens of homes and clashing with the Jordanian military, leaving 15 Jordanian soldiers dead. The raid deeply embarrassed **King Hussein** of Jordan, who publicly accused President Nasser of hiding behind UN peacekeepers instead of helping defend his Arab allies. The Air Clash of 7 April 1967: Skirmishes on the Syrian border erupted into full-scale combat when Syrian artillery on the Golan Heights began bombarding Israeli tractors farming in the demilitarised zone. The Israeli air force responded aggressively. In a dramatic aerial dogfight over Damascus, Israeli fighter jets shot down six Syrian Soviet-built MiG-21 jets in a single afternoon. This humiliating defeat left the Syrian leadership desperate to find a way to restore their military honor.

Q4. What was the outcome of the April 1967 air clash over Damascus, and how did it affect the Syrian leadership?

THE MAY 1967 CASCADE: CHRONOLOGY OF CRISIS

13 May → *Soviet Misinformation*: USSR falsely tells Nasser Israel is massing troops on Syria.

15 May → *Egyptian Mobilization*: Nasser puts army on alert, moves troops into Sinai.

16 May → *UN Out*: Nasser orders UN peacekeepers (UNEF) to evacuate the border buffer.

23 May → *Maritime Blockade*: Egypt closes the Straits of Tiran, choking Israel's port of Eilat.

30 May → *Encirclement*: **King Hussein** of Jordan signs a joint defence pact with Egypt.

The humiliation of the April air clash set off a rapid chain reaction in May 1967 that made a major regional war virtually inevitable. The Catalyst: Soviet Misinformation (13 May). The Soviet Union intervened by issuing a formal, highly urgent warning to President Nasser, claiming that Israel was massing ten brigades on the Syrian border for a full-scale invasion. This report was completely false—UN observers on the ground confirmed there was no Israeli troop build-up—but it placed Nasser under immense pressure to act.

Q5. How did the Soviet Union's misinformation in May 1967 act as a catalyst for the crisis?

Nasser's Gamble: Accused of cowardice by Jordan and Syria, Nasser decided he had to demonstrate his leadership of the Arab world. On 15 May, he placed the Egyptian army on high alert and marched his troops across the Suez Canal into the Sinai Desert. On 16 May, he ordered the UNEF commander to immediately withdraw all UN peacekeepers from the Sinai border, leaving the Egyptian and Israeli armies standing face-to-face. Closing the Straits of Tiran (23 May): In his most dangerous move, Nasser ordered Egyptian troops to reoccupy Sharm el-Sheikh and closed the Straits of Tiran to all Israeli shipping. Israel had repeatedly declared that closing the Straits would be considered a formal casus belli (an act of war), as it choked off its oil imports and trade through Eilat.

Q6. Identify two dangerous gambles President Nasser took between 15 May and 23 May 1967.

The Jordan-Egypt Defence Pact (30 May): To Israel's horror, King Hussein of Jordan flew to Cairo and signed a mutual defence treaty with Nasser, placing the Jordanian army under the command of an Egyptian general. Israel now faced a fully coordinated military encirclement on three fronts by armies openly calling for its destruction. Believing an Arab invasion was imminent, the newly formed Israeli National Unity Government—including war hero **Moshe Dayan** as Defense Minister—decided to launch a pre-emptive strike to secure its survival.

The Air War: Operation Focus (5 June 1967). On the morning of 5 June 1967, Israel launched Operation Focus, the most successful pre-emptive air strike in modern military history. At 7:45 AM, nearly the entire Israeli air force flew low over the Mediterranean Sea to evade Egyptian radar, catching the Egyptian air force completely by surprise as they ate breakfast. Within three hours, Israeli jets bombed the runways and destroyed 309 of Egypt's 340 combat aircraft while they were still parked on the tarmac.

Q7. Describe the success of Operation Focus launched by the Israeli air force on 5 June 1967.

Later that day, when Syria, Jordan, and Iraq entered the war, Israel turned its jets on their airfields, destroying their air forces as well. By the end of day one, Israel had secured absolute air superiority, guaranteeing its ground forces total protection and leaving Arab infantry completely exposed to aerial attack.

OPERATION FOCUS: 5
JUNE 1967

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graph TD; A[OPERATION FOCUS: 5<br/>JUNE 1967] --> B[Low-altitude surprise air<br/>strike]; B --> C[Egyptian radar successfully<br/>bypassed]; C --> D[ ];
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Low-altitude surprise air
strike

Egyptian radar successfully
bypassed

Bomb runways & destroy
309 Egyptian jets



Total Israeli air superiority
secured

The Land War: The Lightning Conquests. With the skies secured, the IDF launched a highly coordinated, three-front blitzkrieg that redrew the map of the Middle East in just six days. The Southern Front (Egypt): Israeli tank divisions led by General **Ariel Sharon** raced across the Sinai Desert, routing the Egyptian forces and advancing all the way to the east bank of the Suez Canal, capturing the entire Sinai Peninsula and the Gaza Strip.

Q8. What were the key territorial conquests of the Israeli Defence Forces during the land war?

The Eastern Front (Jordan): After Jordan began shelling West Jerusalem, Israeli forces launched a fierce counter-offensive. They captured the entire West Bank and, in a deeply emotional victory, took control of the Old City of East Jerusalem, reuniting the city under Jewish control for the first time in 2,000 years. The Northern Front (Syria): On 9 June, Israeli forces turned north and scaled the steep cliffs of the Golan Heights under heavy Syrian fire, capturing the strategic plateau and putting the Syrian capital of Damascus within range of Israeli artillery.

By the time a United Nations ceasefire took effect on 10 June 1967, the war was over. Israel had achieved a miraculous victory, defeating three major Arab armies and expanding its territory to three times its pre-war size.

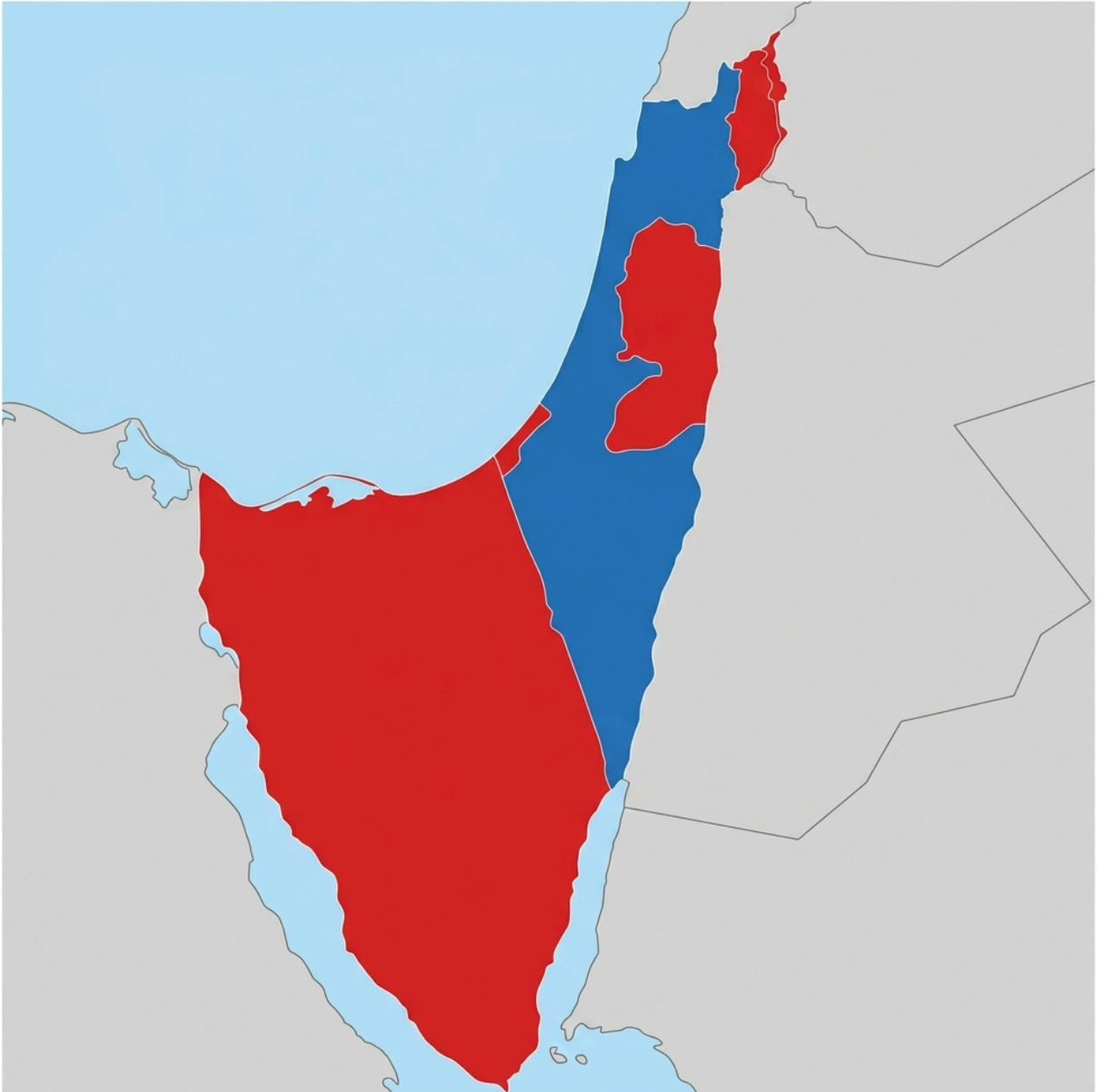
Captured Territory	Captured From	Strategic Value
Sinai Peninsula	Egypt	Vast desert buffer zone
Gaza Strip	Egypt	Eliminated Fedayeen bases
West Bank	Jordan	Defensible borders (Jordan)
East Jerusalem	Jordan	Holy Sites (Western Wall)
Golan Heights	Syria	Protected Galilee farming

Q9. Write a narrative account analysing the key events of the May 1967 crisis that led to the outbreak of the Six Day War. (8 marks)

Pair & Share Activity

Q10. Was Israel justified in launching a pre-emptive strike against Egypt? Discuss both perspectives.

The Six-Day War Map



Map detailing the massive territorial gains made by Israel during the Six-Day War.

Israeli Paratroopers at the Western Wall

 Source

Israeli paratroopers standing in awe at the Western Wall after capturing the Old City of Jerusalem.

Operation Focus

 Source

Israeli aircraft dominating the skies after destroying the Egyptian Air Force on the ground.

GCSE Exam Practice

Write a narrative account analysing the key events of the Six Day War (1967). (8 marks)

Planning your narrative account:

Remember to link your paragraphs chronologically. You could use these sentence starters:

- *The first key event was...*
- *This directly led to...*
- *Consequently, this triggered...*
- *This situation culminated in...*

L2: KT2.2: The Aftermath of the 1967 War

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Understand UN Resolution 242 and the continued dispute over the Suez Canal.
- ☐ Analyze the situation of Palestinian refugees and the significance of the occupied territories: Golan Heights, Gaza Strip, West Bank, Sinai and East Jerusalem.
- ☐ Evaluate the use of terrorism, Israel's response and international attitudes towards the Palestine issue: the PFLP airplane hijacks of 1970; Black September and the Munich Olympics; and the expulsion of the PLO from Jordan (1970).

The Six Day War left Israel holding territories completely inhabited by Palestinians: the West Bank, Gaza Strip, and East Jerusalem. While Israelis celebrated the reunification of Jerusalem, the UN passed Resolution 242 demanding they withdraw. The ongoing occupation of these lands remains the core of the conflict today.

Did you know?

- Resolution 242: The famous UN resolution stating 'land for peace', demanding Israeli withdrawal from occupied territories.
- The PLO: Following the Arab defeat, the Palestinian Liberation Organisation emerged as an independent military force.
- East Jerusalem: Israel unilaterally annexed the eastern half of the holy city, a move not recognised internationally.

Do Now Activity

1. What major political organization was established at the Cairo Conference in January 1964 with the backing of the Arab League, and what was its primary objective?

2.



Who is this leader, and what organisation did he take over in 1969?

3. Explain how disputes over water resources between Israel and Syria in the mid-1960s contributed to rising regional tensions.

4. What was the Samu Raid of November 1966, and how did it affect King Hussein of Jordan's position?

5. What major air battle occurred on 7 April 1967, and how did it affect Syrian military morale?

6. How did the Soviet Union act as a catalyst for the May 1967 crisis?

7. Detail three specific actions taken by Gamal Abdel Nasser in May 1967 that Israel considered a direct casus belli (act of war).

8. What was Operation Focus, launched on 5 June 1967, and why was it so critical to the outcome of the war?

9. List the territories captured by Israel during the Six Day War and identify the nation from which each was taken.

10. Write an analytical sentence linking the May 1967 Crisis to the ultimate outcome of the Six Day War.

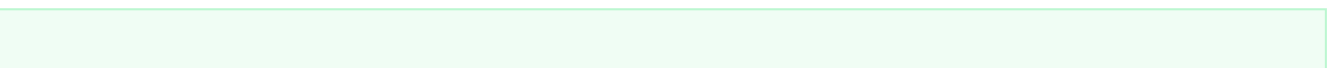
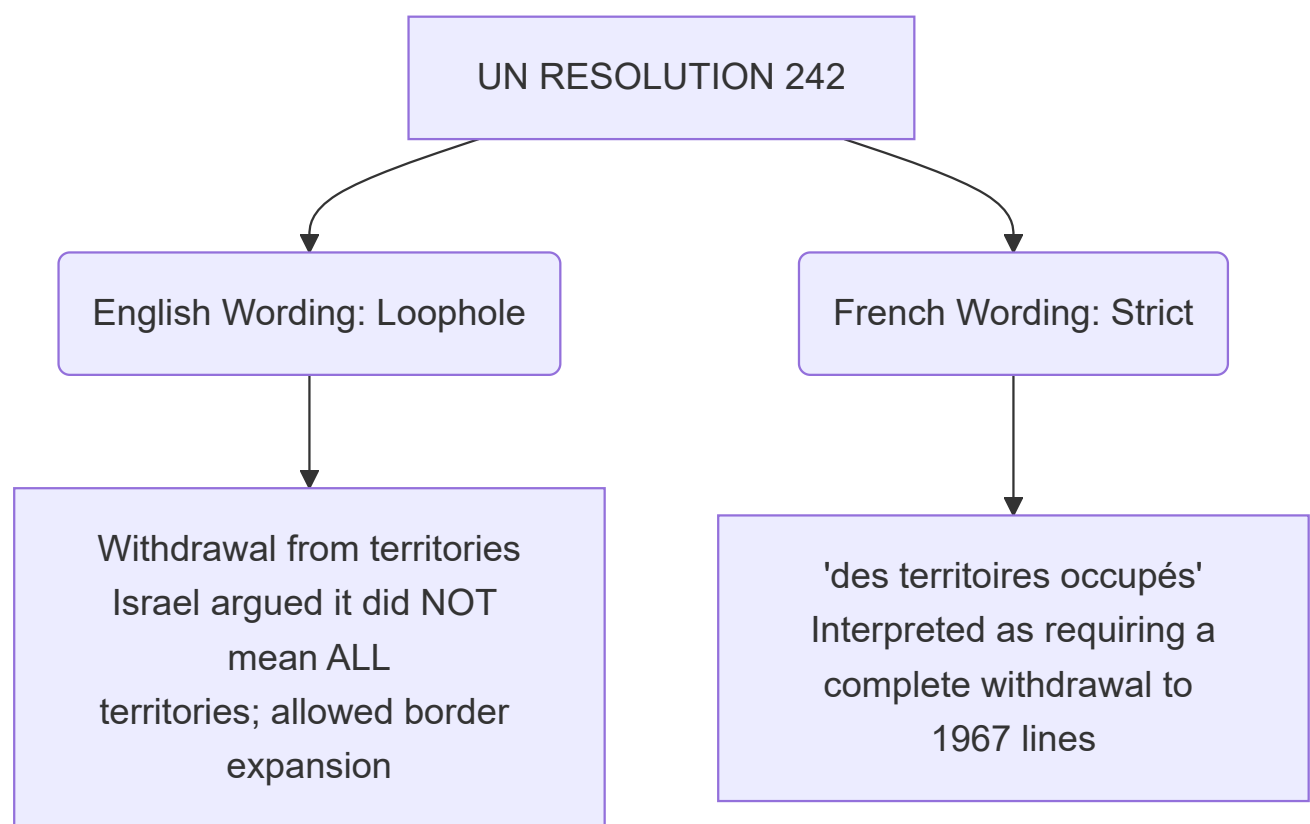
Vocabulary Check

Write a historically accurate sentence connecting two terms from the glossary box below.

UN Resolution 242 | Khartoum Resolution | PFLP | Black September | Operation Wrath of God

Your Sentence:

The lightning ending of the Six Day War left the Middle East in a deep diplomatic deadlock. On 22 November 1967, the United Nations Security Council unanimously adopted Resolution 242. This resolution was designed to establish the guiding principles for a "just and lasting peace" in the region, introducing the fundamental "land for peace" formula. Resolution 242 stressed the "inadmissibility of the acquisition of territory by war" and called for: 1. The withdrawal of Israeli armed forces from territories occupied in the conflict. 2. The termination of all states of belligerency, and respect for the right of every state in the area to live in peace within secure and recognized borders. 3. A just settlement of the refugee problem.



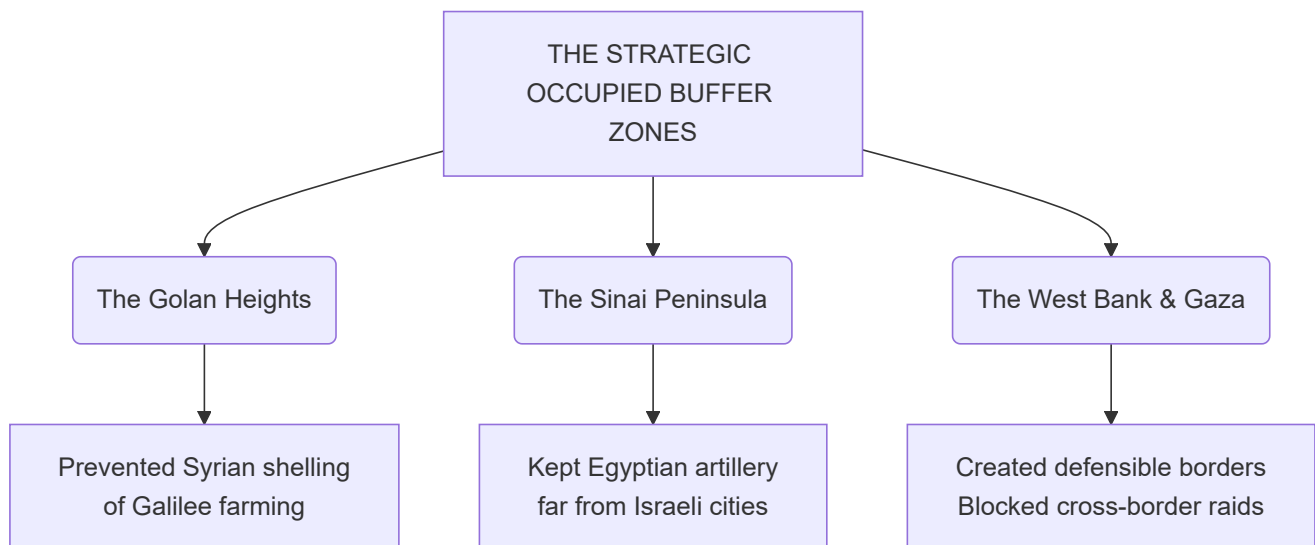
However, the resolution's deliberate ambiguity created long-term loopholes that both sides exploited. The English text called for withdrawal from "territories occupied," omitting the definite article 'the'. Israel's government argued this meant they were not required to withdraw from all the occupied land, but rather from some territories, to ensure "secure and recognized" borders. Conversely, the equally official French version translated the phrase as "des territoires occupés" (from the territories), which the Arab states interpreted as a mandate for a complete Israeli return to the pre-war boundaries. The PLO immediately rejected Resolution 242 because it referred to the Palestinians merely as a "refugee problem" rather than as a nation with a legitimate right to self-determination and statehood.

Q1. How did Israel and the Arab states interpret the ambiguous wording of UN Resolution 242 differently?

The Arab states responded defiantly at the Arab League Summit in Khartoum in August 1967. They issued the famous "Three Nos" of Khartoum: No peace with Israel, No recognition of Israel, and No negotiations with Israel. This diplomatic deadlock meant the Suez Canal—which Egypt had blocked at the start of the war—remained closed. The canal became a heavily fortified military front line separating the Egyptian army on the west bank from the IDF on the east bank, leading directly to the War of Attrition (1969–1970). The Six Day War triggered a second massive wave of Palestinian displacement. Approximately 300,000 Palestinian Arabs fled the West Bank and Gaza Strip during the fighting, with many being forced to flee for a second time from existing refugee camps.

Q2. What was the defiant response of the Arab states at the August 1967 Arab League Summit in Khartoum?

The vast majority crossed the River Jordan, putting immense economic strain on Jordan. This left over 1.5 million Palestinians living under military occupation or in crowded, temporary UNRWA camps.



For Israel's security, the captured territories held immense strategic and military significance. The territories acted as vast physical buffers. The Sinai Desert kept Egyptian artillery far from Israel's borders, the West Bank created a defensible border along the River Jordan, and the Golan Heights prevented Syria from shelling Israeli farming villages in Galilee. The Golan Heights also provided vital water sources, while the Sinai Peninsula offered oil fields in the Gulf of Suez. Israel immediately annexed East Jerusalem, declaring the unified city its eternal capital.

Q3. Explain the strategic significance of the captured territories for Israel's military security.

However, the occupation quickly became a source of deep political and demographic division. In September 1967, Israel established its first Jewish settlement in Gush Etzion on the West Bank. Under both Labor and Likud governments, Israel promoted a policy of building Jewish settlements in the occupied territories, offering financial subsidies and tax breaks to settlers. By the late 1980s, the number of settlers rose to over 200,000, creating permanent "facts on the ground" that fragmented Palestinian society, restricted movement through military checkpoints, and deeply alienated the local Arab population. The total military defeat of conventional Arab armies in 1967 convinced Palestinian nationalists that they could not rely on Arab states to liberate their homeland. Under Yasser Arafat's leadership, the PLO shifted toward guerrilla warfare and irregular tactics.

Q4. How did the Israeli policy of building Jewish settlements in the occupied territories impact the local Arab population?

Simultaneously, more radical, Marxist splinter groups emerged, most notably the Popular Front for the Liberation of Palestine (PFLP), founded by George Habash.

Conventional Arab Armies
Defeated 1967

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graph TD; A[Conventional Arab Armies Defeated 1967] --> B[Grassroots Nationalist Awakening]; B --> C[Radical Splinter Groups Form e.g. PFLP]; C --> D[ ];
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Grassroots Nationalist
Awakening

Radical Splinter Groups
Form e.g. PFLP

Strategy of Internationalized Terror



Dawson's Field Hijackings
1970



World Spotlight Forced
onto Palestinian Issue

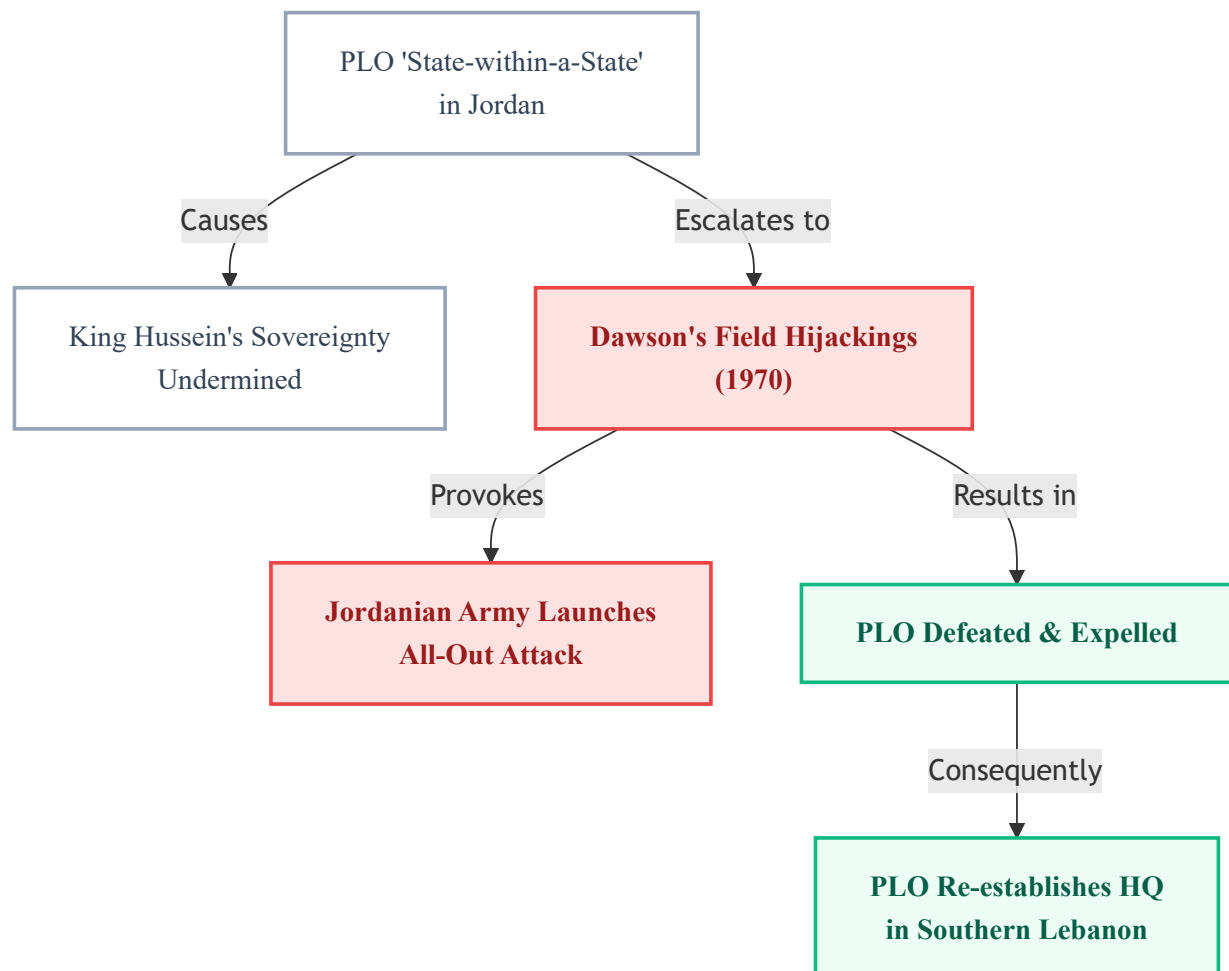
To force the Palestinian issue onto the international diplomatic stage, the PFLP pioneered international aviation terrorism. On 6 September 1970, PFLP militants hijacked four international commercial airliners bound for New York and forced three of them to land at Dawson's Field, a remote desert airstrip near Zarka in Jordan. After evacuating the passengers, the hijackers blew up the multi-million-dollar aircraft in front of the world's media. This dramatic event succeeded in grabbing global attention, but it also deeply embarrassed Jordan's King Hussein, whose sovereignty had been publicly undermined.

Q5. Why did the Popular Front for the Liberation of Palestine (PFLP) hijack commercial airliners to Dawson's Field in 1970?

By 1970, the PLO had established a virtual "state-within-a-state" inside Jordan, collecting its own taxes, running checkpoints, and launching unauthorized rocket attacks on Israel, which drew destructive Israeli military reprisals onto Jordanian territory. The Dawson's Field hijackings were the final straw for King Hussein. He realized that the PLO threatened to overthrow his Hashemite monarchy and plunge Jordan into a civil war.

Q6. Why did King Hussein of Jordan view the PLO as a threat to his sovereignty by 1970?

THE BLACK SEPTEMBER CIVIL WAR



On 17 September 1970, King Hussein declared martial law and ordered his elite, British-trained army to launch an all-out military offensive against PLO bases in Amman and northern Jordan. This brutal, ten-day civil war became known as "Black September". The Jordanian army used heavy artillery and tanks in crowded refugee camps, crushing the PLO forces.

Q7. What was the outcome of the 'Black September' civil war in Jordan in 1970?

Defeated and politically isolated, Yasser Arafat and thousands of PLO fighters were forcibly expelled from Jordan. They relocated their central headquarters to Lebanon, establishing a new base of operations in southern Lebanon (known as "Fatahland") and Beirut, which destabilized Lebanon's delicate political balance. In the wake of their defeat in Jordan, a radical, highly secretive PLO splinter group calling itself "Black September" was formed to conduct covert operations against Israeli and Western targets. Their most notorious attack occurred during the Munich Olympic Games in September 1972.

On 5 September 1972, eight heavily armed Black September terrorists scaled the fence of the Olympic Village in Munich, killing two members of the Israeli Olympic team and taking nine others hostage. The terrorists demanded the release of 234 Palestinian prisoners held in Israeli jails. During a botched rescue attempt by West German police at the Fürstenfeldbruck military airfield, the terrorists detonated a grenade inside a helicopter containing the bound hostages. In total, 11 Israeli athletes, five terrorists, and one German police officer were killed. The massacre unfolded on live television, shocking a global audience of hundreds of millions. It drew severe international condemnation of Palestinian terrorism, but it also succeeded in giving the Palestinian cause unprecedented public visibility.

Q8. Describe the events and consequences of the 1972 Munich Olympic Games terrorist attack.

In response, Israeli Prime Minister **Golda Meir** ordered the IDF to launch heavy bombing raids against PLO camps in Lebanon and Syria. More significantly, she authorized the Mossad to launch "Operation Wrath of God"—a highly secretive, global assassination campaign that hunted down and killed the key planners of the Munich massacre across Europe and the Middle East.

Q9. Write a narrative account analysing the key developments in the Palestinian issue in the years 1970–72. (8 marks)

Pair & Share Activity

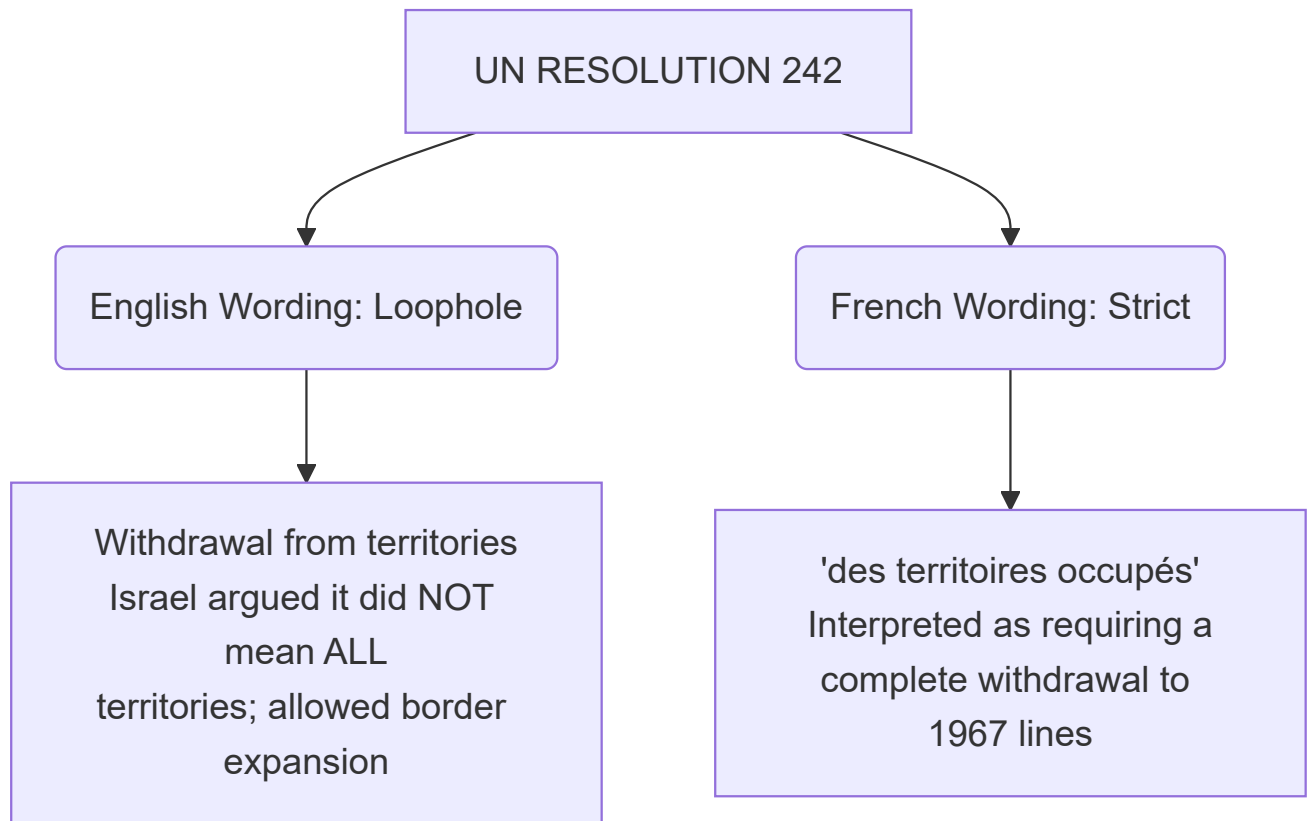
Q10. Why did the spectacular Israeli victory in 1967 actually make a long-term peace agreement more difficult?

The Khartoum Resolution



Egyptian President Gamal Abdel Nasser, who led the Arab rejectionist stance at the 1967 Khartoum Conference with the famous 'Three No's'.

UN Resolution 242



UN Resolution 242, which established the 'Land for Peace' formula for resolving the Arab-Israeli conflict.



GCSE Exam Practice

Explain one consequence of the Six Day War (1967). (4 marks)

L3: KT2.3: Israel and Egypt, 1967–1973

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Analyze Egyptian relations with Israel, the USA, the USSR and other Arab states.
- ☐ Understand Israel's consolidation of control of the occupied territories.
- ☐ Describe the key events of the Yom Kippur War (1973) and its aftermath.

Determined to avenge the humiliation of 1967 and regain the Sinai Peninsula, Egypt's Anwar Sadat launched a surprise attack on Israel during Yom Kippur, the holiest day in the Jewish calendar. The initial Arab success shattered Israel's feeling of invincibility and forced them back to the negotiating table.

Did you know?

- Yom Kippur: October 6, 1973, when Egyptian and Syrian forces launched their coordinated surprise attack.
- The Bar Lev Line: The supposedly impenetrable Israeli sand defenses along the Suez Canal, which Egypt breached in hours using water cannons.
- Oil Embargo: Arab oil-producing states stopped selling oil to countries supporting Israel, causing a global economic crisis.

Do Now Activity

1. What major United Nations Security Council Resolution was passed on 22 November 1967 to establish the guiding principles of a 'land for peace' formula?
2. Name the radical, Marxist-leaning Palestinian group founded by George Habash that pioneered international aviation terrorism in the early 1970s.
3. Explain how a translation discrepancy in the wording of UN Resolution 242 created a loophole that hindered its implementation.
4. What Arabic term refers to the Arab League Summit of August 1967, and what were the famous declarations issued there?
5. What was the immediate result of the Dawson's Field hijackings of September 1970 for the PLO's position in Jordan?
6. To which country did the PLO relocate its central headquarters after its expulsion from Jordan in 1970–71?
7. Describe the events of the Munich Olympics of September 1972 and state how Israel's Prime Minister Golda Meir responded.
8. How did Israel's capture of the Golan Heights, the West Bank, the Gaza Strip, and the Sinai Peninsula in 1967 initially improve its military security?
9. Why did the PLO reject UN Resolution 242?
10. Write an analytical sentence linking the outcome of the Six Day War to the rise of international Palestinian terrorism.

Vocabulary Check

*Write a clear definition and a historically accurate sentence for the term: **War of Attrition***

The immediate aftermath of the 1967 war did not bring peace, but rather a grueling, undeclared border war along the Suez Canal known as the War of Attrition (1969–1970). Egyptian President Gamal Abdel Nasser refused to accept the static Israeli occupation of the Sinai Peninsula. Backed by massive military aid from the Soviet Union, Nasser launched a continuous campaign of heavy artillery shelling, commando raids, and rocket barrages across the Suez Canal to wear down the Israeli Defence Forces (IDF) and make the occupation too costly to sustain.

THE COLD WAR ESCALATION ON THE SUEZ



Nasser launches artillery
bombardments



Israel retaliates with deep
air strikes





Egypt receives 15,000
Soviet advisors



Soviet SAM-3 missile sites
built 1970



US mediates August 1970
Ceasefire



Uneasy stalemate remains unaddressed

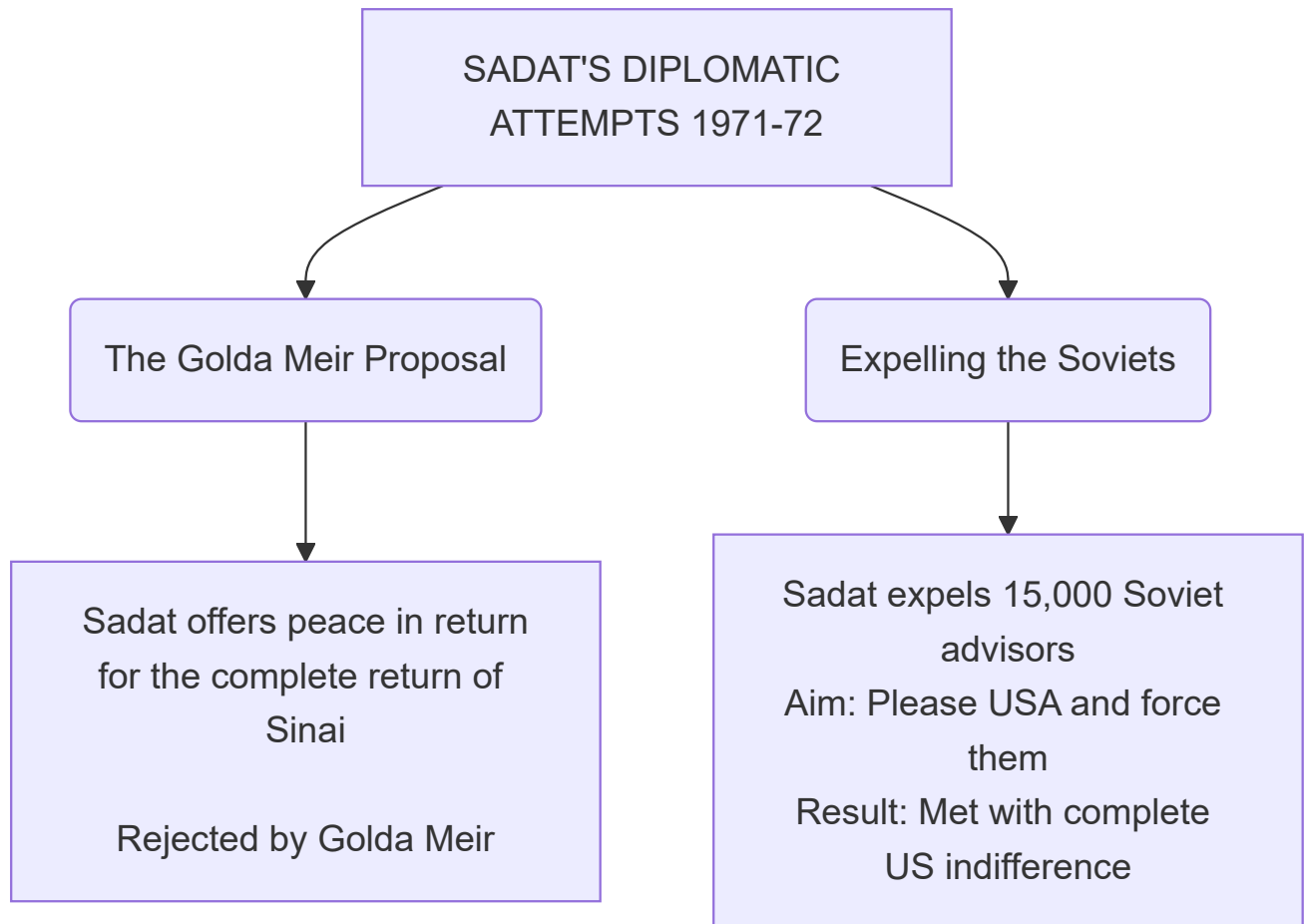
Israel responded aggressively by utilizing its absolute air superiority to conduct deep-penetration bombing raids into Egypt, targeting Egyptian military garrisons, industrial factories, and infrastructure along the Nile. To protect his regime, Nasser turned directly to his Soviet patrons. By 1970, approximately 15,000 Soviet military advisers were stationed in Egypt. Soviet pilots actively flew combat missions, engaging Israeli jets in dogfights over the canal, while Soviet engineers constructed advanced SAM-3 surface-to-air missile bases along the Suez front.

Q1. How did Israel respond to Nasser's artillery bombardments during the War of Attrition, and what was Nasser's reaction?

Alarmed that this direct superpower clash could drag the United States and the USSR into a global conflict, US Secretary of State William Rogers intervened. In August 1970, he successfully brokered a ceasefire that halted the active fighting. However, neither Egypt nor Israel was committed to substantive peace talks. Shortly after, on 28 September 1970, the strain of regional politics took its toll when Nasser suffered a sudden, fatal heart attack. His death shocked the Arab world. Five million mourners flooded the streets of Cairo for his funeral, marking the end of the charismatic era of Pan-Arabism.

Nasser was succeeded by his relatively unknown and underestimated Vice President, **Anwar Sadat**. Sadat inherited a country on the brink of political and economic collapse. Egypt's economy was severely damaged by the continuous military mobilization, the Suez Canal was closed (depriving Egypt of vital transit toll revenues), and millions of displaced civilians had fled the devastated cities along the canal zone. Sadat realized that to rebuild Egypt's economy and send home his one million mobilized soldiers, he desperately needed to secure the return of the Sinai Peninsula and reopen the Suez Canal.

Q2. Why did Anwar Sadat believe he desperately needed to secure the return of the Sinai Peninsula?



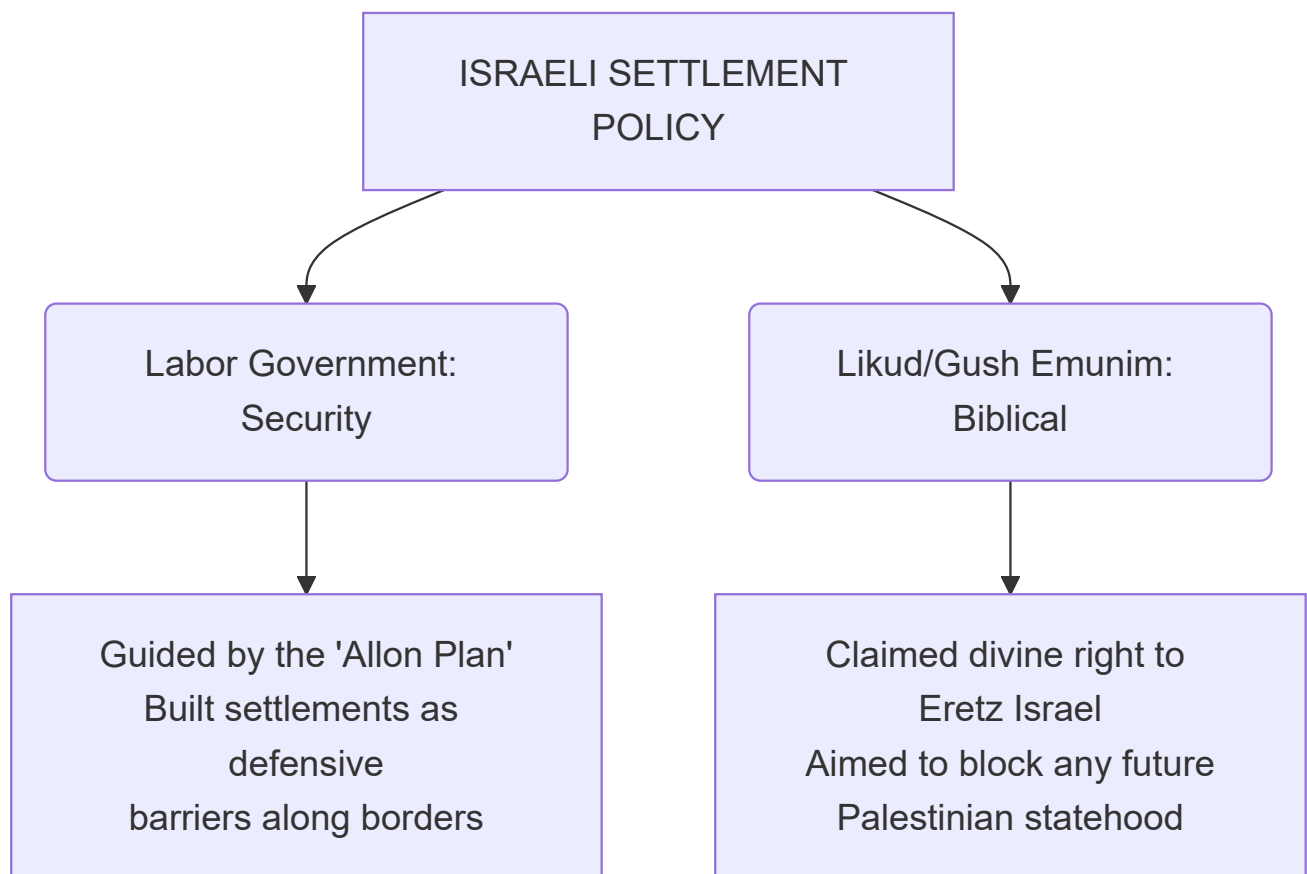
Between 1970 and 1972, Sadat pursued two distinct diplomatic tracks: The "Peace for Sinai" Offer and Expelling the Soviet Advisers. Sadat approached Israeli Prime Minister Golda Meir with a bold proposal based on UN Resolution 242. He offered a formal peace agreement and the reopening of the Suez Canal in exchange for Israel returning the Sinai Peninsula. Confident in their military superiority, Golda Meir and her cabinet rejected the offer, refusing to return to the vulnerable pre-1967 borders.

Q3. What was the 'Peace for Sinai' offer proposed by Anwar Sadat, and why did Golda Meir reject it?

Frustrated by Soviet reluctance to supply him with offensive weapons and hoping to win diplomatic favor with the United States, Sadat took the dramatic step of expelling 15,000 Soviet advisers from Egypt in July 1972. He calculated that this anti-communist move would prompt the US to pressure Israel into territorial concessions. However, the Nixon administration was preoccupied with the Vietnam War and met Sadat's gesture with total indifference. By late 1972, Sadat's popularity had plummeted to its lowest point. The Egyptian public mocked him, the economy was stagnant, and the Sinai remained firmly in Israeli hands. Sadat realized that Israel would never negotiate as long as it felt militarily secure. He concluded that Egypt's only option was to launch a limited, surprise military strike to shatter the myth of Israeli invincibility and force the global superpowers to intervene and broker a diplomatic solution.

Q4. Why did Sadat expel 15,000 Soviet advisers from Egypt in July 1972, and what was the US reaction?

While Egypt struggled with stagnation, Israel utilized the years between 1967 and 1973 to consolidate its firm military and political control over the Occupied Territories (the Sinai, Gaza, West Bank, Golan Heights, and East Jerusalem). Israel's policy transitioned from a temporary military occupation to a permanent program of state-sponsored colonization.



Along the east bank of the Suez Canal, Israel constructed a massive military fortification. The Bar Lev Line consisted of a towering, 20-meter-high artificial sand wall backed by concrete bunkers, artillery emplacements, and early-warning systems designed to make any Egyptian crossing of the canal impossible. Israel began constructing permanent civilian communities (settlements) in the captured lands. The ruling Labor coalition focused on establishing defensive settlements in strategic buffer zones, such as the Jordan Valley. However, religious-nationalist groups like Gush Emunim began establishing unauthorized, radical settlements deep in the biblical lands of the West Bank.

Q5. What was the Bar Lev Line, and what was its purpose?

By 1973, these settlements had become permanent "facts on the ground," deeply fragmenting Palestinian society and convincing Arab leaders that Israel was expanding permanently. On 6 October 1973, Sadat's secret plan for war was put into action. Egypt and its ally, Syria, launched a highly coordinated, two-front surprise attack against Israel.

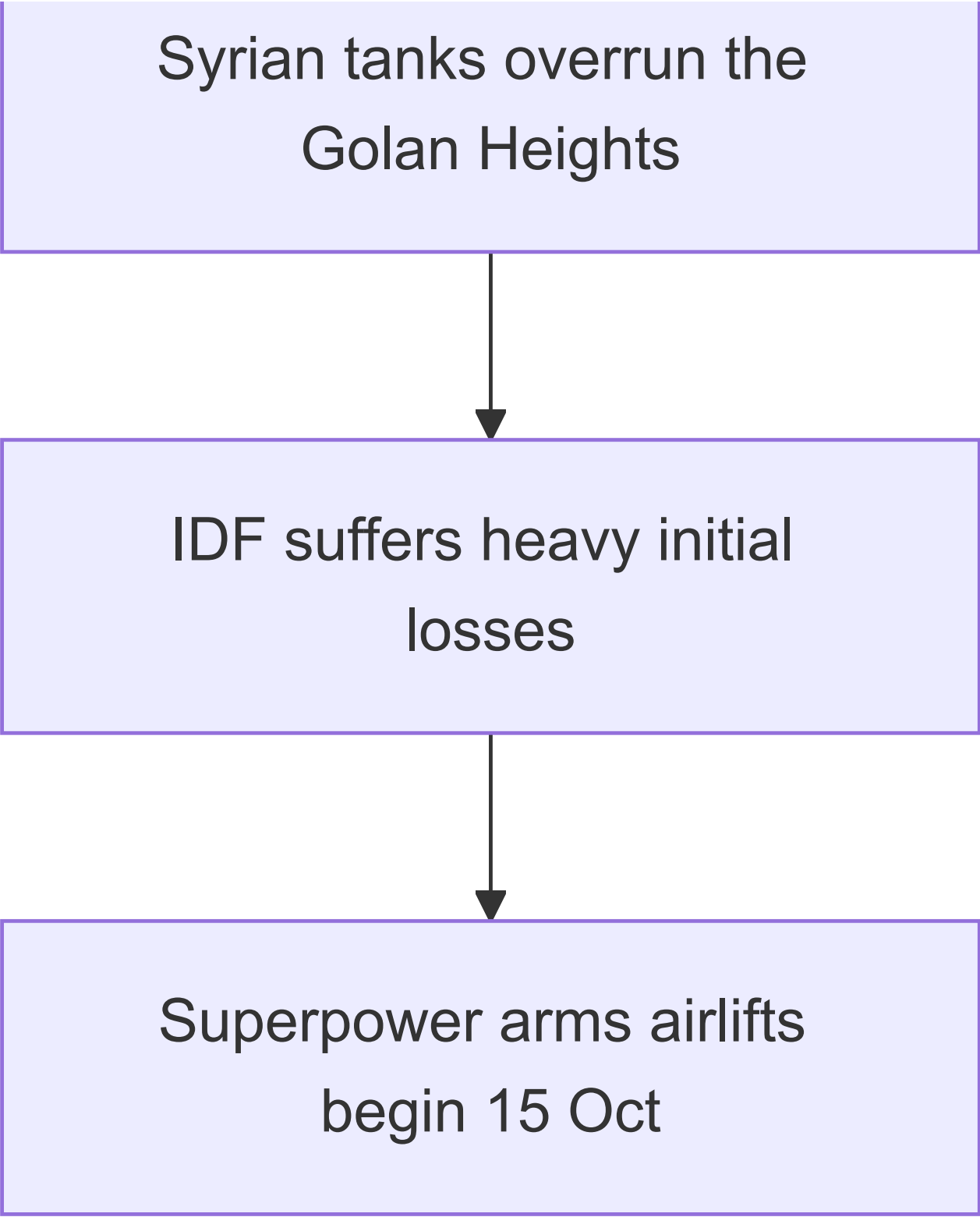
Surprise Attack launched
on Yom Kippur

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graph TD; A[Surprise Attack launched on Yom Kippur] --> B[IDF caught off-guard; mobilization slowed]; B --> C[Egyptians breach the Bar Lev Line]; C --> D[ ];
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IDF caught off-guard;
mobilization slowed

Egyptians breach the Bar
Lev Line

**Syrian tanks overrun the
Golan Heights**



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graph TD; A["Syrian tanks overrun the Golan Heights"] --> B["IDF suffers heavy initial losses"]; B --> C["Superpower arms airlifts begin 15 Oct"]
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**IDF suffers heavy initial
losses**

**Superpower arms airlifts
begin 15 Oct**

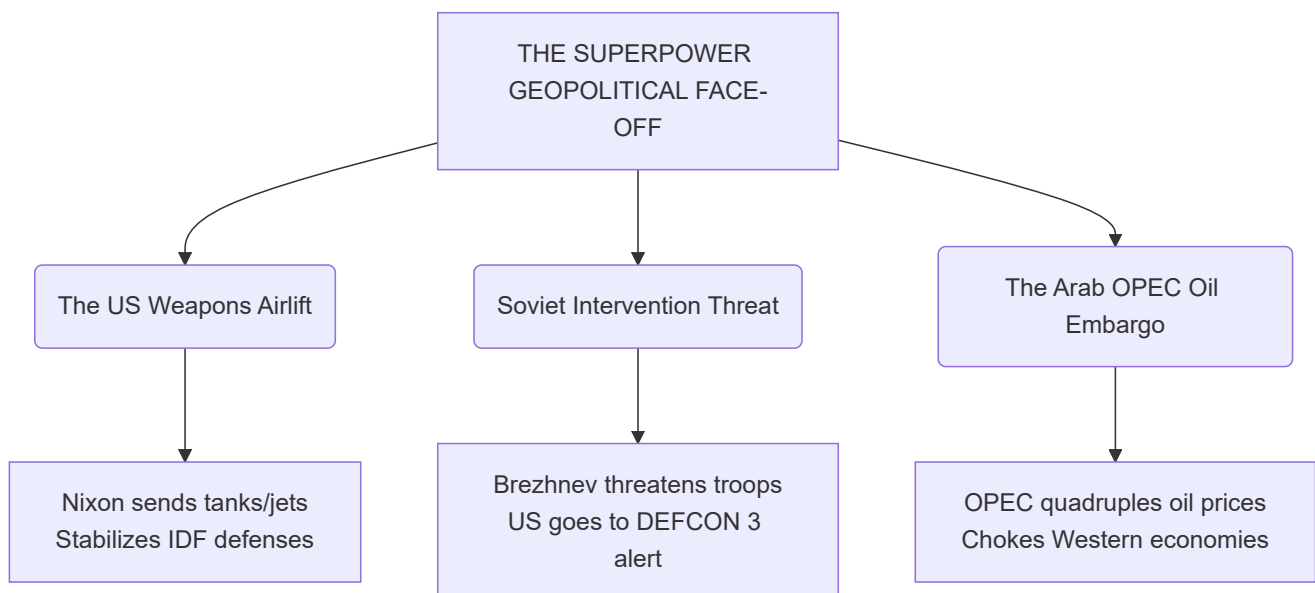
The offensive was launched on Yom Kippur, the holiest day in the Jewish calendar. On this day, Israel was at a complete standstill: radio stations were silent, shops were closed, public transport was shut down, and most soldiers were at home fasting. This severely delayed the mobilization of the IDF's reserve forces. Egyptian forces crossed the Suez Canal and used high-pressure water hoses pumped from the canal to rapidly wash away and breach Israel's formidable sand-wall defenses at the Bar Lev Line. Within hours, thousands of Egyptian infantry and tanks poured into Sinai, utilizing advanced Soviet-supplied anti-tank (Sagger) and anti-aircraft (SAM) missiles to destroy Israeli counter-attacks.

Q6. How did the Egyptian army successfully breach the Bar Lev Line at the start of the Yom Kippur War?

Simultaneously, Syrian tank divisions launched a massive assault across the Golan Heights, overrunning Israel's thin border defenses and threatening to break through into the Galilee. Caught completely off-guard, Israel suffered catastrophic initial casualties. For the first three days, the survival of the state hung in the balance. By 10 October 1973, Israeli reserves were fully mobilized, and the tide of the war began to turn through ruthless military execution and vital international assistance. On the Northern Front, the IDF successfully halted the Syrian advance and pushed Syrian forces back beyond the 1967 border.

On the Southern Front, the conflict escalated into a massive superpower proxy war. To replace Israel's heavy losses, US President Richard Nixon authorized Operation Nickel Grass on 12 October—a massive, direct military airlift of advanced American weapons, tanks, and ammunition that arrived in Israel on 15 October. Simultaneously, the Soviet Union launched an equally massive arms resupply to Egypt and Syria. Utilizing their newly arrived equipment, Israeli tank divisions led by General **Ariel Sharon** exploited a gap between Egypt's Second and Third Armies. The IDF crossed the Suez Canal onto the Egyptian mainland, destroying Soviet-bloc SAM missile sites and completely encircling Egypt's Third Army in the Sinai Desert.

Q7. Describe the superpower proxy conflict that emerged during the Yom Kippur War.



As the Egyptian Third Army faced complete destruction, the Soviet Union threatened to intervene directly by deploying Soviet troops to Egypt. To deter the Soviets, the United States put its military forces on a high-alert status (DEFCON 3), bringing the world to the brink of a nuclear confrontation. To resolve the crisis, the UN Security Council passed Resolution 338 on 22 October, calling for an immediate ceasefire.

To force the United States to restrain Israel, the Arab members of OPEC unleashed the "Oil Weapon." They placed a total oil embargo on the US and Western nations that supported Israel, cutting production and quadrupling oil prices from \$3 to \$12 a barrel.

Q8. How did the Arab members of OPEC attempt to force the United States to restrain Israel?

Choked by a severe global energy crisis and fuel shortages, President Nixon pressured Israel into accepting a permanent ceasefire on 25 October 1973.

THE SIGNIFICANCE OF THE YOM KIPPUR WAR		
For Egypt	For Israel	For the Peace Road
Sadat restored Egyptian honor and proved the Bar Lev Line was not invincible.	Golda Meir and Moshe Dayan resigned due to immense public anger over initial war failures.	Proved military force had limits; forced US into exhaustive "shuttle diplomacy".

Q9. Write a narrative account analysing the key developments of the Yom Kippur War (1973) and its aftermath. (8 marks)

Pair & Share Activity

Q10. How did the Yom Kippur War change the psychological balance of power between Israel and the Arab states?

The Yom Kippur War (1973)



Egyptian forces successfully crossing the Suez Canal during the surprise attack on Yom Kippur in 1973.



General Ariel Sharon leading the Israeli counter-offensive across the Sinai desert towards Egypt in the later stages of the Yom Kippur War.

Golda Meir



Israeli Prime Minister Golda Meir, whose government faced severe criticism for lack of preparedness in 1973.

GCSE Exam Practice

Write a narrative account analysing the key events of the Yom Kippur War (1973). (8 marks)

Planning your narrative account:

Remember to link your paragraphs chronologically. You could use these sentence starters:

- *The first key event was...*
- *This directly led to...*
- *Consequently, this triggered...*
- *This situation culminated in...*

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